WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

NEW ZEALAND

Asia

Information current as of November 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Auckland	Largest city and commercial capital, home to the main financial, corporate and technology base and the Ports of Auckland, the first project consented under the new fast-track regime	Financial services, technology, property, logistics
Wellington	Capital and seat of government, regulators and the Reserve Bank; centre for policy engagement and the creative and screen industries	Government relations, professional services, film and digital
Tauranga / Bay of Plenty	Port of Tauranga handled 1.21 million TEUs in the year to June 2026 and is expanding through dredging and the proposed Stella Passage development	Port logistics, horticulture (kiwifruit), forestry exports
Christchurch / Canterbury	South Island's main commercial hub and gateway to the country's largest agricultural plains, with a growing technology and manufacturing base	Agribusiness, food processing, technology, manufacturing
Taranaki	Centre of the domestic oil and gas industry and the planned location for a new LNG import facility to strengthen energy security	Energy, LNG infrastructure, engineering services
Southland	Home to the Tiwai Point aluminium smelter, secured to 2044 by 20-year electricity agreements, and a deep pool of renewable hydro generation	Aluminium, renewable energy, data centres, dairy
Waikato and central North Island	Core dairy and forestry region within the Auckland–Hamilton–Tauranga 'golden triangle' freight corridor, with significant geothermal resources	Dairy, forestry, geothermal energy, logistics

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Invest New Zealand, the national investment promotion agency launched in 2025 within NZTE, offering facilitation and sector guidance for foreign investors in areas such as infrastructure, energy, financial services and manufacturing

- Reformed Overseas Investment Act, in force since 6 March 2026, replacing three tests with a single national interest pathway for most assets, a 15-working-day statutory timeframe and a target of five working days for most applications
- Fast-track Approvals Act one-stop consenting for nationally significant projects, with 149 listed projects and 33 approvals by expert panels as of September 2026
- Active Investor Plus visa offering residence for investments of at least NZ$5 million (Growth) or NZ$10 million (Balanced), with NZ$1.42 billion completed or committed by March 2026
- Free-floating New Zealand dollar under an independent Reserve Bank, with free movement of capital and no restrictions on profit repatriation
- Infrastructure participation through the National Infrastructure Plan's pipeline of nearly 12,000 projects worth about NZ$275 billion, including public-private partnerships and regional projects
- Listed-market entry and capital raising via NZX, the national stock exchange, complemented by a deep professional-services and common-law legal environment

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

New Zealand in October 2026 offers investors one of the most transparent and open operating environments in the Asia-Pacific, with an economy that has returned to growth and a government actively courting foreign capital. GDP rose 0.2% in the June 2026 quarter after an upwardly revised 0.9% in the March quarter, taking growth over the year to 1.7%, with construction (+2.7%) and export volumes (+3.3%, led by meat and dairy) leading the recovery. Goods exports rose 15.4% year-on-year in August 2026, with strong gains to Japan, Australia and China. Reform momentum is substantial: the reformed Overseas Investment Act, in force since March 2026, introduces a single national interest test with a 15-working-day timeframe; Invest New Zealand now provides dedicated investor facilitation; the Fast-track Approvals Act has approved 33 major projects; and the New Zealand–India free trade agreement enters into force on 20 October 2026. FDI inflows were about $2.5 billion in 2025, against an inward FDI stock of roughly $96 billion.

New Zealand's principal structural challenge is to modernise its infrastructure and energy system while managing exposure to global price shocks. The 2026 fuel-price spike linked to Middle East conflict lifted annual inflation to 4.1% in the June quarter before it eased to 3.7% in the September quarter, and the Reserve Bank responded by raising the Official Cash Rate to 2.75% in September and holding it in October, with inflation projected to return to the 1–3% target band by mid-2027. The economy has absorbed the shock well: the current account deficit narrowed to about 3.2% of GDP and the net international liability position fell to 39% of GDP, its lowest share this millennium. The government is addressing declining domestic gas supply through a planned LNG import facility in Taranaki, alongside a renewable electricity build-out and faster consenting. The National Infrastructure Plan identifies a pipeline of nearly 12,000 projects worth about NZ$275 billion, more than two-thirds of which lack full funding — a significant opening for long-term private and foreign capital.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Infrastructure funding gap	More than two-thirds of the NZ$275 billion project pipeline lacks full funding, and renewals will absorb around 60% of infrastructure spending over 30 years	The government is opening the pipeline to private capital, creating opportunities in PPPs, water, transport, health and energy assets
Energy security and gas supply	Declining domestic gas output and reliance on hydro (57% of capacity) can cause price volatility in dry years	A planned LNG import facility, renewable expansion and fast-track consenting support supply; investors in energy and storage stand to benefit
Imported inflation and rising interest rates	Fuel prices lifted annual inflation to 4.1% in mid-2026 (3.7% in the September quarter) and the OCR has risen to 2.75%, with further tightening possible	Core inflation excluding fuels is within target; build modest rate and cost buffers into financing plans
Screening of sensitive assets	Farmland, residential land and fishing quota retain separate, more demanding consent pathways under the Overseas Investment Act	Engage the Overseas Investment Office and specialist counsel early; most business assets now use the streamlined 15-working-day route

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Distance from major markets	Geographic remoteness adds freight costs and lead times for goods trade	Extensive FTA coverage, port investment and a focus on high-value food, services and digital exports offset distance
Fiscal consolidation	Net core Crown debt is forecast to peak at 46.1% of GDP in 2027/28, with a return to surplus projected for 2028/29	Debt remains moderate by advanced-economy standards; fiscal restraint encourages private co-investment in public infrastructure
Election cycle	A general election is scheduled for 7 November 2026, which may shift some policy priorities	New Zealand's stable institutions and consistent rule of law limit transition risk; monitor party positions on foreign investment settings

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

New Zealand's risk profile is that of a stable, high-income democracy with strong institutions, transparent regulation, an independent central bank and consistently high rankings for rule of law and low corruption. The 2026 reforms to the Overseas Investment Act, the creation of Invest New Zealand and fast-track consenting represent a genuine and sustained shift towards welcoming foreign capital. The main near-term considerations are imported inflation, a rising interest-rate cycle and the scale of funding needed for infrastructure and energy, but these are well understood and the economy's resilience is clear from the narrowing current account deficit and an improved external balance sheet. Investors in sensitive land, farmland or fishing quota should plan for longer consent processes, while those in energy should factor in short-term price volatility. The general election on 7 November 2026 is a routine democratic transition rather than a source of instability, and investors can expect continuity in New Zealand's open-market orientation.

MARKET ACCESS

New Zealand is a founding WTO member and a member of both the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP) and the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP), giving preferential access across most of the Asia-Pacific. Its Closer Economic Relations agreement with Australia creates a deeply integrated trans-Tasman market, and bilateral FTAs with China, the United Kingdom and the European Union are complemented by the New Zealand–India FTA, which enters into force on 20 October 2026 with 57% of New Zealand exports to India tariff-free from day one. China, Australia, the United States, Japan and the EU are the leading export markets, with dairy, meat, horticulture, forestry and tourism as core earners. Upper North Island ports, led by Tauranga and Auckland, anchor export logistics, giving investors a well-connected platform for serving Asia-Pacific markets.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the Prime Minister (Christopher Luxon)	Sets the government's growth agenda, including foreign-investment liberalisation, trade expansion and infrastructure delivery	Primary reference point for strategic direction ahead of the November 2026 election
Invest New Zealand	National investment promotion agency, incubated within NZTE, facilitating foreign investment and approving Active Investor Plus investments	Standard first point of contact for market entry and project facilitation
Reserve Bank of New Zealand	Independent monetary authority setting the Official Cash Rate (2.75%) and supervising banks	Relevant for financing conditions, banking and currency matters
Overseas Investment Office (Land Information New Zealand)	Regulator administering the reformed Overseas Investment Act and its national interest test	Essential counterpart for any acquisition of significant business assets or sensitive land
The Treasury and Minister of Finance	Leads fiscal and economic policy,	Key for understanding fiscal settings and

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
(Nicola Willis)	including Budget allocations and infrastructure funding frameworks	public co-investment opportunities
New Zealand Infrastructure Commission (Te Waihanga)	Authors of the 30-year National Infrastructure Plan and publisher of the national project pipeline	Valuable source of project intelligence for infrastructure investors
Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Trade and Minister for Trade and Investment (Todd McClay)	Leads FTA negotiations and implementation, including the new India FTA	Relevant for market-access opportunities and trade-linked investment

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The American Chamber of Commerce in New Zealand, the Europe New Zealand Business Council and bilateral chambers with the UK, Australia, China and India are active platforms for foreign investors, alongside BusinessNZ and regional chambers of commerce for domestic liaison. Invest New Zealand and NZTE run investor programmes and trade missions, while Fast-track and National Infrastructure Plan processes provide transparent public pipelines of major projects. The New Zealand Infrastructure Commission's pipeline data and industry forums are useful for identifying co-investment opportunities, and New Zealand's sophisticated legal, accounting and advisory sector supports efficient due diligence and transaction execution.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

New Zealand suits long-term investors seeking stable, rule-of-law exposure to the Asia-Pacific: infrastructure and pension funds targeting the NZ$275 billion project pipeline and PPP opportunities; renewable energy, storage and LNG-related investors addressing energy-security needs; agribusiness and food-processing investors building on world-class dairy, meat and horticulture sectors and expanded FTA access, including India; technology, data-centre and screen-industry investors drawn by skilled talent and renewable power; and high-net-worth investors using the Active Investor Plus pathway to back growth companies and managed funds.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage Invest New Zealand early
Open dialogue with the national investment promotion agency to identify sector opportunities, facilitation support and relevant government contacts.

STEP 2: Map the Overseas Investment Act pathway
Confirm whether the transaction qualifies for the streamlined 15-working-day national interest route or a sensitive-land pathway, and prepare documentation with specialist counsel.

STEP 3: Target the infrastructure and energy pipeline
Use the National Infrastructure Plan pipeline and Fast-track Approvals list to identify projects seeking private capital, particularly in energy, water, transport and health.

STEP 4: Leverage New Zealand's FTA network
Structure export-oriented investments to benefit from CPTPP, RCEP and the newly in-force India FTA, alongside established access to China, Australia, the UK and the EU.

STEP 5: Plan around the rate and election cycle
Build interest-rate and energy-cost scenarios into financing, and track post-election policy settings following the 7 November 2026 general election.